

BEHIND THE GAMES

Designing a modern game is no easy task (as we discovered!). To unearth how these marvels are made we travelled half way around the world to one of most reputed development studios in the business. Read about our Epic journey...

Michael Browne

When it comes to gaming, most of us, (and we include ourselves), are a very choosy bunch. We wait for a title for either an hour playing the game, we're either with a grin on our faces...or not. In event of the latter, the game is proclaimed a failure and dismissed. What is also forgotten, however, is the sheer volume of sweat and human perseverance that went in from inception to completion of the game, and the labour of love that developers put in throughout its development. The idea to visit a game studio to find out exactly what goes on there, began sometime in mid-March. We decided to visit Epic Games (of *Unreal Tournament* fame) headquartered in the tiny, picturesque, and very green township of

Cary—which itself is a suburb of the much larger City of Oaks a.k.a. Raleigh, North Carolina. Connected by flight via the Raleigh-Durham airport. Cary at first glance seems a quaint place with a miniscule populace—a conducive atmosphere for game development in our opinion.

After a hearty American-style breakfast, it was time to behold the lair of Epic itself. The first impression, (and one that lasts), given off by the surroundings, the building and the people themselves, is of a very casual, and laid back atmosphere underlining a very professional outfit. The grounds, complete with open lawn and a basketball court at the rear of the building and parking at the front that shows off some amazing gardening skills, add to the effect that the management at Epic wanted to create, "a place that's soothing to the soul."

Inside the building, a quick look at the work area shows a very fresh and different look

to each office's décor and colour. Senior management have individual offices, otherwise two or three other employees may share a room, albeit with excellent desk segregation. This is done to aid concentration, and maintain human contact throughout work hours. Throughout the tour of the building, we saw many examples of a home-like environment, from the do-it-yourself fully stocked kitchen, to the lounge, replete with pool and table tennis tables, chairs, large screen TV, and arcade games. Equally cool, was their gaming den, a large hall-like room with some 16 gaming setups. Each setup consisted of an Xbox 360, a PS3 and an SLI-configured HP Blackbird PC complete with quad core processor and 4 GB of memory! By now, you're thinking "Wow! Wouldn't I like to work there". Don't berate yourself up for any disloyal thoughts. You aren't the first to consider such possibilities (shhhh!).

After a brief tour that included a peek at their fully equipped gym, the guys at Epic were ready to talk about something we all love—games. But first, a little background lesson. Tim Sweeney, CEO and founder (1991), of Epic Games, has been designing games from his college days and is a die-hard gamer in his free time. Epic games (then called Epic MegaGames) itself kicked off with *Jill of the Jungle* way back in 1992. Their first huge title, (and one we all remember and relate to), was *Unreal* (1998), was possible due to the teaming up of Epic with two gifted individuals—Cliff Bleszinski and James Schmalz.

Once inside their conference room, we settled into comfy sofas. The walls were liberally plastered with art work and renders from Epic's upcoming title *Gears Of War 2* (GOW 2). There were soft drinks, burgers and other snacks, well within arms reach, throughout the session. The current focus of Epic is very

obviously on GOW 2.

For those who don't know, the original GOW (released in November 2006) was one of the best X360 titles till date. In fact, GOW alone accounted for a noticeable hike in the sales of the console after its release. Although the sequel is set for November this year, we're told that the game is ready, and testing and fine tuning gameplay is currently in progress. The team has been at work on this prequel, the original. For us, GOW was one of the best efforts at a third-person shooter on any console, simply because of the amazing player control and camera angles. In fact, we fondly remember the happy hours spent at GOW, and quite a few of our team got hooked on the game. In short, GOW came close to delivering a PC-like third person experience. But as Cliff Bleszinski ("Cliffy B" to everyone) says, "the best is yet to come". The team is candid about the shortcomings of the first title, and it's obvious they won't repeat the same mistakes with GOW 2. It's clear that their work is their passion, and everybody seems thrilled to be asked about the game itself. Even silly questions we put forward are answered patiently and accurately.

Having played GOW so much, we put forward the obvious—How is GOW 2 better? Epic answers "In every way". We want specifics particularly of the eye-candy variety. Mike

